States contributing roughly three-quarters of NATO's defense spending, Trump lambasted the alliance for placing a disproportionate financial burden on the United States. He repeatedly demanded that other member states increase their defense budgets to ease the strain on American resources. Trump's grievances extended beyond funding; he advocated for rapprochement with Russia (Schuette and Dijkstra 2023), in stark contrast to NATO's stance, and called for a realignment of priorities, suggesting the alliance should focus solely on countering China.[36]

Trump's insistence on a more balanced distribution of financing across members became a focal point of his criticism. He declared that the United States would only guarantee the defense of members meeting the NATO guideline of allocating at least 2 percent of their GDP to defense, a policy first established in 2014.[37] His rhetoric escalated further when he suggested that the United States might withhold support from Baltic nations unless they fulfilled these obligations.[38] Trump's refusal to unequivocally endorse NATO's foundational Article V, which enshrines the principle of collective defense, alarmed allies.[39] At one point, Trump came perilously close to withdrawing the United States from NATO entirely, consistent with his pattern of exiting multilateral organizations during his presidency.

In response to Trump's criticisms and threats, NATO employed a range of strategies to manage the situation and preserve the alliance. One approach was to appease Trump by urging members to increase defense spending and framing these efforts as a direct result of his demands. Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg actively encouraged member states to boost their contributions and publicly credited Trump for these increases, positioning him as a driving force behind the alliance's financial changes.[40] Stoltenberg personally met with Trump in 2018, highlighting an additional $100 billion in defense commitments reportedly secured through Trump's pressure, a figure that was trumpeted by Trump as a major achievement.[41]

NATO also sought to appeal to Trump's base by leveraging public relations campaigns. Stoltenberg appeared on *Fox News*, a network favored by Trump and his supporters, to emphasize Trump's role in deterring Russia by spurring greater financial contributions from member states.[42] This strategy aimed to bolster Trump's domestic image as a leader securing tangible wins for the United States while reinforcing NATO's relevance to his core supporters. Efforts to "Trump-proof" the alliance included ensuring